

AI Coding Agents: Complete Comparison

Cline vs Cursor vs Kilocode vs OpenCode Finding the Optimal Solution with OpenRouter Integration

1. Executive Summary

This comprehensive analysis compares four leading AI coding agents: Cline, Cursor, Kilocode, and OpenCode. OpenCode emerges as a particularly compelling option with 95K+ GitHub stars and 2.5 million monthly developers, positioning it as one of the most popular open-source AI coding tools. The comparison evaluates each platform against the core requirements: cloud-based inference, top-tier model access, strong coding capabilities, and generous free usage through OpenRouter integration. OpenCode distinguishes itself with a terminal-first approach, built-in free models, and support for 75+ LLM providers while remaining completely open-source.

2. Feature Comparison Matrix

Feature	Cline	Cursor	Kilocode	OpenCode
Type	VS Code Extension	Standalone IDE	VS Code/JetBrains/CLI	Terminal/Desktop/IDE
GitHub Stars	~40K	N/A (closed)	~15K	95K+
Users	5M+	~2M+	1M+	2.5M/month
Open Source	Apache 2.0	No	Apache 2.0	Apache 2.0
Free Models	Via OpenRouter	Limited requests	Via Gateway	Included
LLM Providers	10+	Built-in only	500+ Gateway	75+
OpenRouter	Full support	No	#1 ranked	Full support
LSP Support	Via VS Code	Built-in	Via VS Code	Auto-load
MCP/Agents	Full MCP	Limited	Full MCP	Custom agents
Terminal CLI	No	No	Yes	Primary (TUI)
Desktop App	No	Yes (IDE)	No	Yes
JetBrains	No	No	Yes	No

Table 1: Feature comparison across all four AI coding agents

3. OpenCode - The Terminal-First Powerhouse

OpenCode has rapidly become one of the most popular open-source AI coding agents, boasting 95,000+ GitHub stars and serving 2.5 million developers monthly. The platform takes a terminal-first approach with a native Terminal User Interface (TUI), while also offering desktop applications and IDE extensions. This architecture appeals to developers who prefer keyboard-driven workflows and want AI assistance without leaving the terminal environment.

3.1 Key Differentiators

Built-in Free Models: Unlike Cline or Kilocode which require external provider setup, OpenCode includes free models out of the box. New users can start coding immediately without configuring API keys. The OpenCode Zen tier provides curated, optimized models specifically tested and benchmarked for coding agent workflows.

LSP Integration: OpenCode automatically loads the appropriate Language Server Protocols for the LLM, enabling intelligent code understanding without manual configuration. This ensures the AI has proper context about syntax, types, and project structure.

Provider Agnostic: OpenCode acts as a neutral layer between developers and AI models, supporting 75+ LLM providers including OpenAI, Anthropic, Google, OpenRouter, and local models via Ollama. Users can switch providers seamlessly based on cost, availability, or performance preferences.

Parallel Execution: Community feedback indicates OpenCode excels at parallel execution and subagent-related tasks compared to Cline. This makes it particularly effective for complex, multi-step operations that benefit from concurrent processing.

3.2 Pricing Tiers

Tier	Cost	Features
Free (Core)	\$0	Open-source, free models included, BYO API keys
OpenCode Go	\$5 first month, then \$10/mo	Generous limits, open-source models, reliable access
OpenCode Zen	\$20/mo	Curated optimized coding models, transparent pricing
OpenCode Black	Custom	All world's best models (Claude, GPT, Gemini), paused

Table 2: OpenCode pricing tiers

4. Requirements Evaluation

Requirement	Cline	Cursor	Kilocode	OpenCode
Cloud Inference	Via OpenRouter	Via Cursor cloud	Via Gateway/OR	Via providers
Top-tier Models	Any (BYO)	Built-in GPT/Claude	500+ models	75+ providers
Coding Quality	Excellent	Excellent	Excellent	Excellent
Free Usage	Via OR free models	Limited (50-500)	\$20 credits + OR	Included + OR
Setup Ease	Medium	Easy	Easy	Very Easy
GitHub Integration	Via Git/MCP	Built-in	Via Git/MCP	Via Git

Table 3: Evaluation against original requirements

5. Category Winners

Category	Winner	Reasoning
Popularity	OpenCode (95K stars)	Largest open-source community and active development
Free Start	OpenCode	Free models included, no API key setup required
Model Selection	Kilocode (500+)	Largest model catalog via Kilo Gateway
IDE Integration	Cursor	Native AI-IDE with polished experience
Terminal/CLI	OpenCode	Primary TUI design, keyboard-driven workflow

JetBrains Support	Kilocode	Only option with JetBrains IDE support
Cost Efficiency	OpenCode / Cline	Both offer unlimited free via OpenRouter
Ease of Setup	OpenCode	Works immediately with built-in free models
LSP Integration	OpenCode	Auto-loads appropriate LSPs for context
Parallel Execution	OpenCode	Better subagent/parallel task support

Table 4: Category winners with reasoning (green = OpenCode wins)

6. Final Recommendations

6.1 Best Overall for Free Usage: OpenCode

OpenCode emerges as the optimal choice for developers seeking powerful AI coding assistance without ongoing costs. With free models included out-of-the-box, 95K+ GitHub stars indicating strong community support, and support for 75+ LLM providers including OpenRouter, it offers the best combination of accessibility, capability, and cost efficiency. The terminal-first design appeals to experienced developers, while the desktop app provides options for those preferring GUI interfaces.

6.2 Best for VS Code Users: Kilocode

Developers deeply integrated into the VS Code ecosystem should consider Kilocode for its seamless extension experience, \$20 free signup credits, and #1 ranked OpenRouter integration. It combines the best features of Cline and Roo Code while adding unique capabilities like JetBrains support.

6.3 Best for Maximum Control: Cline

Power users who prioritize complete control over their AI coding environment should choose Cline. Its mature MCP ecosystem, transparent provider relationships, and 5M+ user base make it a reliable choice for developers comfortable with configuration.

6.4 Best for Polished IDE Experience: Cursor

Developers willing to pay \$20/month for a refined, all-in-one experience should choose Cursor. Its native AI-IDE integration, cloud agents, and Bugbot feature provide premium capabilities at a reasonable subscription cost.

7. Conclusion

OpenCode represents a compelling new contender that challenges previous recommendations. Its combination of built-in free models, terminal-first design, massive community (95K+ stars), and support for 75+ providers positions it as potentially the best choice for developers seeking accessible yet powerful AI coding assistance. For users prioritizing zero-cost operation with OpenRouter integration, both OpenCode and Cline/Kilocode offer viable paths, with OpenCode having the edge in ease of setup and included free models, while Kilocode offers superior IDE integration and broader model catalog. The final choice depends on workflow preferences: terminal-centric developers should choose OpenCode, while VS Code devotees may prefer Kilocode's extension-based approach.